

HOW I RECOVERED SUDO ACCESS ON LINUX AFTER LOCKING MYSELF OUT



A Missing Flag That Cost Me Sudo

While configuring a Linux server, I wanted to add my user (hosni) to a new group called `sec`.

So I ran this command:

```
usermod -G sec hosni
```

But here's the problem: I forgot to add `-a` (append).

What this command did was replace all my group memberships with just one — `sec`.

As a result:

- I was removed from the `sudo` group
- I completely lost `sudo` privileges
- I couldn't run any command with `sudo`
- I was locked out of administrative access

The Recovery: Step-by-Step Fix from GRUB

Even though I lost sudo, I still had a way in — by using the root recovery mode via GRUB.

Here's exactly how I recovered my sudo access:

1 - Reboot and Access GRUB

Restart the system.

On the boot screen, press Esc or Shift (depending on your distro) to bring up the GRUB menu.

2 - Select Recovery Mode

Choose the line that says something like:

Advanced options for Ubuntu

Then select the Recovery mode kernel (e.g., Ubuntu, with Linux x.x.x (recovery mode)).

GNU GRUB version 2.02~beta2-36ubuntu3.27

```
Ubuntu, with Linux 4.15.0-213-generic
*Ubuntu, with Linux 4.15.0-213-generic (recovery mode)
Ubuntu, with Linux 4.15.0-142-generic
Ubuntu, with Linux 4.15.0-142-generic (recovery mode)
```

3 - Choose the "root" Shell Option

In the Recovery Menu, select:

root Drop to root shell prompt

This gives you temporary root access without needing sudo or a password.

```
Recovery Menu (filesystem state: read-only)

resume          Resume normal boot
clean           Try to make free space
dpkg            Repair broken packages
failsafeX       Run in failsafe graphic mode
fsck            Check all file systems
grub            Update grub bootloader
network         Enable networking
root            Drop to root shell prompt
system-summary  System summary
```

<Ok>

```
root@ubuntuserver:~# _
```

4 - Remount the Filesystem as Read-Write

By default, the system is mounted as read-only in recovery mode.

You must remount it as read-write to make changes.

```
mount -o remount,rw /
```

5 - Add Your User Back to the Sudo Group

Now use `usermod` correctly to add yourself back to the `sudo` group:

```
usermod -aG sudo hosni
```

This time, the `-a` flag tells the system to append the `sudo` group without removing your other groups.

6 - Reboot the System

Exit and reboot:

```
reboot
```

Once back in your normal session, test `sudo`:

```
sudo whoami
```

It should return `root`. Access recovered!